

Apps: E-mail, Web Browsers, Chat, Audio and more

The following apps are some of the apps pre-installed with Ubuntu. Note that they are just the basics. Check out Chapter Seven for the low down on the wonders of awesome Linux software. To launch your apps, just click on the '9 dots' icon at the bottom of the Dock and you'll see all of the Apps on your system just waiting for you to explore!

Browsing the web

Ubuntu has Firefox pre-installed. You can download Google Chrome from the Google Chrome if that's your fancy though (Chromium is also available in the App store – it's a free alternative to Chrome, made by Google, just without the proprietary bits). You'll find each of these browsers work in exactly the same way as it does on Windows or Mac.

E-mail and Calendar

Whilst Thunderbird is now the default Email client for Ubuntu (with the Lightning calendar add-on), GNOME also ties in closely with Evolution. Evolution is a powerful e-mail, calendaring and contact management productivity tool which can connect to your online accounts (eg Google, Microsoft Exchange etc). It works very much like Microsoft Outlook on a Windows PC does. Of course, if you prefer another email client, there's plenty more to choose from!

Music / Radio and Video

Rhythmbox works like iTunes or similar. Copy your music from your Windows/Mac over to your Linux hard drive and you can play your tunes straight away. You can even mount your Windows/Mac hard drive partition so you don't have to copy your music. You can also play music from Internet radio stations and cloud based audio including SoundCloud.

To view video files, simply click on your video in the File browser and it will launch the GNOME Video player. It's no-nonsense approach is lovely, however if you are after a more fully featured video player, then there are tons to pick from. The most popular video player is VLC, which is a cross-platform app that, whilst is a little more complex, it'll play just about any movie file under the sun.

Image Viewer / Photos

As with all of the built-in GNOME apps, they are deliberately simple in nature. The files which are in the 'Pictures' folder, which is inside your Home folder, are automatically displayed. To organise your photos, you can assign photos to customised albums, and mark some as favourites.

If you have hooked up an online account which supports photo sharing (Google Photos for example), then you will see all of your cloud photos in there too (it will take a long time to synchronise if you are like me with thousands of photos!).

GNOME Photos is great for viewing and sorting, however, if you want to edit the photo, you will need a photo editing tool. If you want something really basic (a drop in replacement for Microsoft Paint), then use Pinta. If you are looking for the full power of something like Photoshop then try GIMP (GNU Image Manipulation Project). Both of these apps can be installed through the Software tool which we mention below.

Word, Excel, Powerpoint: LibreOffice.

LibreOffice is the de-facto Office suite for open source computer users. It supports Microsoft Office formats (mostly), and using the applications feel just like they should do. LibreOffice Writer is for

word processing, Calc is for spreadsheets. Impress is for presentations. Math is for complex calculations. Whatever your office productivity needs, LibreOffice should have it covered.

GNOME also comes with an app called Documents, which allows you to view cloud based and local copies of PDFs and other cloud format files (eg Google Spreadsheets/Docs).

The Rest

- Chat: Talk online using Google Talk, AIM, Jabber, IRC etc, use Empathy.
- BitTorrent Downloads: Transmission is your friend.
- Zipped up files: Use file roller to decompress and compress file archives.
- Scanning: Simple Scan will get you started.
- Text Editing: Gedit edits text files easily.
- Webcam: For snapping with your webcam, there is Cheese.
- Weather: Yep, you guessed it, the Weather app is imaginatively titled, “Weather”!

How do I install more Apps?

There are hundreds of thousands of free apps just waiting to be explored in Linux. From CAD to Calculators, MS Visio alternatives to Vehicle maintenance apps.

To install anything, just launch the Software Center. In GNOME, its simply called ‘Software’, but each distribution may call it something slightly different. Ubuntu Software, Software Center, App Store, Software Boutique; you get the idea!

For a very quick introduction to how to install software via the Software Center or via more traditional methods, see this tutorial.

Now that you are well on your way to being a bonafide Linux desktop user, have a look at Chapter Seven, which introduces you to many more fantastic open source apps, from E-Mail to music players, games to video editing, even how to use your Linux machine as a TV!